

Colour me Pink

A new auto service in Le Corbusier's town adds colour to the city and energises the transport department



Haryana



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**CHANDIGARH GETS A
TRANSPORT MAKEOVER**

| By Arvind Chhabra |

Apparently inspired by Thailand's Tuk Tuk, the Chandigarh administration has started its dial-an-auto service by the same name. Dial a number and the pink-coloured autos come "tuktuking" to your doorstep, a service the administration says is the first of its kind in the country. Of course, the city has its radio cabs that are faster, air-conditioned and save you the increasing pollution. Yet, autos have their own advantages; they weave in and out of heavy traffic and narrow lanes, offer cheaper rides than taxis, and the service has now eliminated the fleecing factor. Here you pay a fixed rate: Rs 10 for the first kilometre and Rs 8 for each subsequent km.

You call a centralised number which spots the nearest autos, equipped with a GPS, and one reaches you in just half an hour. The service was started with much fanfare and promised to give frills such as bottled water and newspapers. But when you ask for these, the girl at the call centre wonders if you are serious. The service initially had two women drivers but now just one

remains. Still, the service is doing very well. "There is only one complaint. The demand exceeds supply and we are soon going to add 25 more to the existing fleet of ten," says Union territory (UT) Transport Secretary Ram Niwas. "We wanted to give them a different look with added features. So we thought, why not have pink autos which appeal to the eye," says UT state Transport Authority Secretary Vandana Disodia, adding that the USP of these autos is the sense of security for women passengers. "Here we know who the auto driver is and what his credentials are. The GPS keeps track of the autos."

Private auto owners don't see a threat. "We will always be in demand," insists Bharat, an auto driver. "We may charge less when we are headed for the same destination, we don't mind packing in more passengers going to the same place and each of them ends up paying less." Chandigarh has always had its share of transport woes but the autos have made commuting in the tricity of Chandigarh, Mohali and Panchkula a little less painful and a wee bit more colourful. ■